



The New TV Superbazaar

The force is with us. The mundane television set has suddenly turned into an incredible technicolour dreamboat. The remote control has placed a glitzy new world at our fingertips. Enormous metallic objects, crammed with electronic gizmos circling the sky, are beaming down a bewildering collage of images. And like a lost tribe discovering an oasis in the desert, lakhs of Indians are hot-wired into this superbazaar of soaps, music, sex and much more. A jumble of international companies now threaten DD's monopoly over a vast but frustrated TV audience.

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to television screens nationwide. India-centric news channels then appeared on the radar, eclipsing CNN and even BBC World, which entered India in 1992.

In 1995, the government sheepishly recognised what was hitherto unlawful with a Cable TV Act. This, though, was carelessly worded, pandered to pressure groups and was obsolete even before it became effective. In fact, the Ministry of Information & Broadcasting has done little to instil order in the present chaos. The absence of a content code, in particular, perpetuates darkness. Cable operators who show adult programmes free-to-air when children may be watching deserve to be punished. At the same time, the mature citizen should not be consigned to the dustbin. Withholding adult programming from an intelligent grown-up is an assault on his fundamental rights. A sensible content code, which recognises the availability of parental control technology and supercedes the Cable Act, is imperative, for unarguably, one man's obscenity is another person's art.

In the dispensation that has developed, only those with deep pockets, churning out banal programming, can be successful. Star TV lost millions of dollars for years before an unoriginal *Kaun Banega Crorepati* saved its bacon in 2000. Even news channels pander to Bollywood and cricket—the other money spinner—to survive. Niche, high quality TV is a non-starter. On the occasion of 60 years of Independence, India urgently needs to organise its broadcasting sector to genuinely fulfil the potential of satellite television.

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